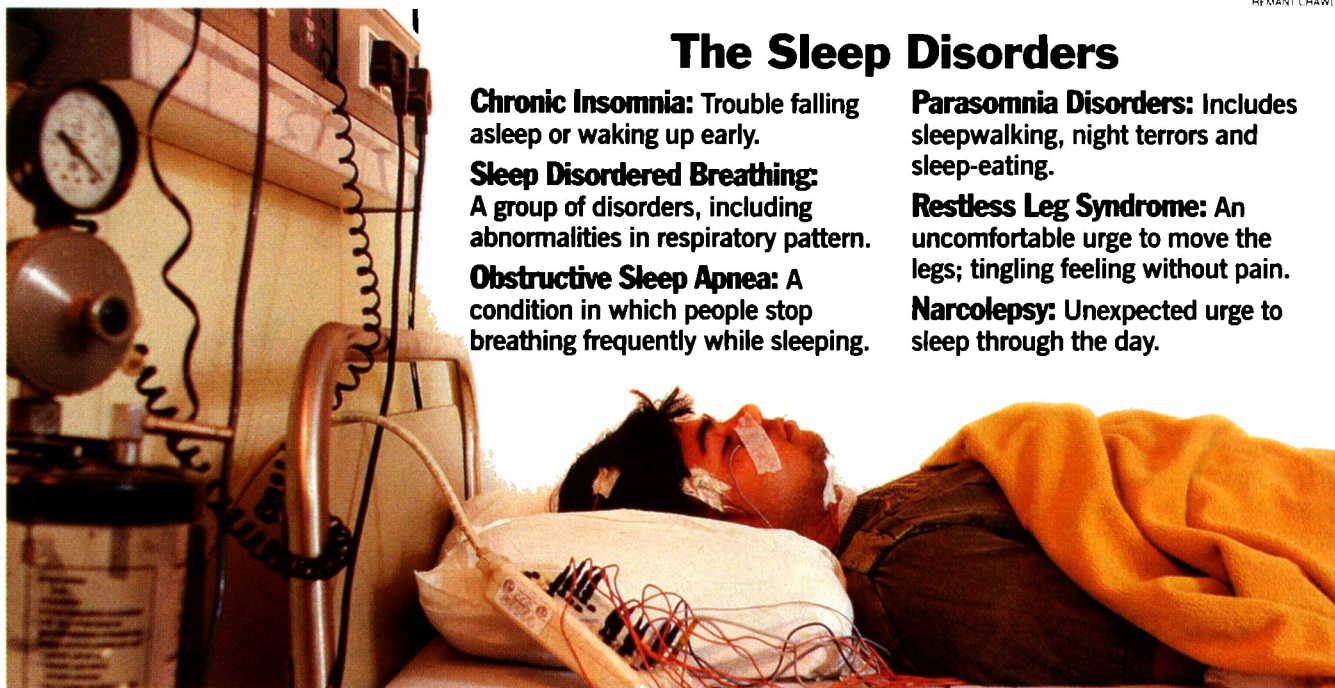




The Sleep Disorders

Chronic Insomnia: Trouble falling asleep or waking up early.

Sleep Disordered Breathing: A group of disorders, including abnormalities in respiratory pattern.

Obstructive Sleep Apnea: A condition in which people stop breathing frequently while sleeping.

Parasomnia Disorders: Includes sleepwalking, night terrors and sleep-eating.

Restless Leg Syndrome: An uncomfortable urge to move the legs; tingling feeling without pain.

Narcolepsy: Unexpected urge to sleep through the day.

harder for people to switch off. "The knock-on effects of the failure to switch off mount at home, while social commitments and 24-hour cable network or the Internet, keep one away from sleep," adds Dr Naveen Thomas, deputy director of Baptist Hospital, Bangalore. A survey of Indian call centre employees by the *Dataquest* magazine in 2005 showed that at least 34 per cent people—falling in the age group of 20-30 years—suffer from various sleep disorders.

The fallout is hardly amusing. Hours of lost sleep can lead to high levels of stress, relationship problems, unhealthy changes in behaviour, all of which have a nasty tendency to exacerbate the problem that caused them.

The obvious signs of sleep-induced stress are abundant: moodiness, irritability and problems with appetite—be it under or over-eating. Whether or not the signs are clear to them, stressed people react in a familiar pattern. For women, the most common positive reaction is to talk to friends, while men turn to physical exercises. Both sexes are also prone to reacting negatively, though—increasing their alcohol consumption, smoking, changing their eating habits and sometimes trying drugs to dampen the anxiety. Those who follow irregular sleep patterns run the risk of heart diseases, high blood pressure, diabetes, substance abuse, among other ailments.

Road accidents, not surprisingly, are a serious fallout of sleep disorder. "OSA is associated with significant morbidity and mortality, both from

vascular complications and from road and industrial accidents," claims a study conducted by AIIMS in 2003. At least 20 per cent of the people under the study were found to have a history of road rage and accidents. "Lack of sleep affects the immune system of your body and also the body reflexes," says Kanwar. Policy analyst, Leo Saldanha, agrees, "Often it is just a matter of one or two seconds of drowsiness that causes major road accidents." Development activist, Augustine Kaunds, who works for the welfare of truck drivers in India, states that in the US about two lakh sleep-related accidents occur every year.

Doctors invariably find a pattern in the type of people who seek help for OSA. Sleep disorders are often correlated with being overweight and are found in men more than in women. The AIIMS study clearly reported that patients with OSA had a significantly higher Body Mass Index (ratio of weight by height) and were more likely to suffer from hypertension and diabetes. In fact, of all the OSA patients they evaluated, 35 per cent had family history of snoring. "Deposition of adipose tissue around the abdomen, diaphragm and ribs lead to an increased effort in breathing," says Guleria. The risk increases as age does.

All this describes a growing number of urban Indians. So, if you are a time-crunched professional, find yourself reading the same paragraphs repeatedly, snore and snuffle at nights and are more irritable than you should be, beware. You could be prey to these disorders. ■

34%

urban Indians between the ages of 20-30 years suffer from sleep disorders



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